Resetting a Strategic Joint Venture to Restore Trust and Unlock Value

Objectives

- Reset the relationship at an executive level
- Rebuild trust and alignment
- Create shared clarity on how value is defined and delivered
- Identify tangible, near-term actions to stabilise the partnership
- Set a foundation for longer-term success across the remaining lifecycle

Context

A large enterprise organisation had entered into a long-term strategic partnership with a global consulting firm, with the ambition of accelerating the adoption of data and AI across the business. The intent was bold: to embed AI across core functions, reshape ways of working, and create a sustained competitive advantage.

However, 12 to 18 months into the relationship, the partnership had reached a critical inflection point.

While progress had been made in pockets, senior leaders across both organisations were increasingly grappling with a lack of clarity around how value was being defined, delivered, and measured. Questions of ownership and accountability had become blurred, and what had initially been positioned as a collaborative effort was beginning to show signs of fragmentation.

At the same time, large-scale shifts in workforce structure — including significant offshoring and the redistribution of roles across geographies — had introduced additional complexity. Time zone challenges, loss of institutional knowledge, and a gradual erosion of trust were beginning to impact not only delivery, but also the broader perception of the partnership across the organisation.

Despite these challenges, the reality was clear: the partnership was not optional. It would continue, and it needed to succeed.

The Challenge

A group of approximately 15 senior executives from across both organisations were brought together for a high-stakes intervention.

The intent was not simply to surface issues or facilitate discussion, but to create the conditions for a meaningful reset. This required rebuilding trust at the leadership level, establishing a shared understanding of what value looked like, and aligning on a set of tangible actions that could stabilise the partnership in the near term while setting it up for longer-term success.

The complexity of the situation meant that the session needed to carefully balance candour with progress. Historical tensions, differing incentives, and sensitivities around accountability all needed to be acknowledged, without allowing the conversation to become unproductive or overly retrospective.

Approach

The engagement was structured as more than a single workshop. It followed a deliberate sequence designed to ensure the right conversations were happening, in the right way, with the right level of depth.

Early stakeholder conversations played a critical role in shaping the intervention, helping to surface underlying tensions and identify where misalignment was most pronounced. This ensured the session focused on the real issues at play, rather than the more visible — but less critical — symptoms.

The workshop itself was designed to create both structure and space. Rather than relying on open discussion alone, a series of carefully crafted prompts were used to guide thinking and elevate the quality of dialogue. In particular, seeded questions were introduced to help participants move beyond surface-level responses and engage more directly with the core challenges facing the partnership.

To support more holistic thinking, a customised concept canvas — inspired by methods from the LUMA Institute — was used to encourage exploration from multiple perspectives. The canvas was specifically tailored to the context, with lenses focused on value definition, operating model clarity, ways of working across geographies, and the human dynamics underpinning trust and collaboration.

This combination of structured facilitation and flexible dialogue allowed participants to engage candidly, while still maintaining forward momentum.

Outcome

While the session was never intended to resolve every structural challenge in a single sitting, it achieved a meaningful shift in both mindset and direction.

Senior leaders were able to re-establish a baseline level of trust, grounded in a more open and shared understanding of the challenges at hand. The conversation moved away from fragmented perspectives and implicit blame, towards a more collective sense of ownership over the partnership and its success.

Importantly, the group aligned on a set of immediate priorities to stabilise the relationship, alongside a number of longer-term focus areas that would require sustained attention. These outcomes were synthesised and shared more broadly, providing a clear signal to the wider organisation that leadership was aligned and actively working towards a more cohesive and effective partnership.

In doing so, the engagement helped shift the trajectory of the joint venture — from one characterised by uncertainty and erosion, to one with renewed clarity, alignment, and intent.